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In Maine race, Democrats sense opening

President's shadow may force LePage to tone himself down

By Sam Brodey
GLOBE STAFF

BREWER, Maine — The campaign for New England's most Trump-friendly House district shouldn't have been a heavy lift for former two-term Republican governor Paul LePage — the self-styled "Trump before Trump."

But stiff headwinds have come in for LePage. Tariff wars and an actual war in Iran have driven up costs for fuel and other necessities to unsustainable levels in this working-class northern Maine district, and all have come as a result of actions taken by the president himself.

That's given Democrats an opening to compete in a race that many had written off after four-term Democratic Representative Jared Golden opted to retire.

Their nominee, state Auditor Matt Dunlap, was not party brass's first choice to take advantage of a favorable midterm environment, or even their second. He first entered the race by challenging Golden, and after the incumbent withdrew, he won a primary over the party's preferred candidate.

Hammering a message focused on the cost of living, Dunlap has seemingly closed the gap, with polls showing a tightening race and independent analysts rating it among the most competitive in the country. Both campaigns and outside groups have spent more than a combined $10 million on it.

In a sign of how Republicans view the race, House Speaker Mike Johnson stumped in Bangor for LePage last week, calling the contest "top five" nationally. Trump himself has yet to campaign for LePage in Maine, but Vice President JD Vance has twice.

After speaking at a town hall event in Brewer last month, Dunlap, who is professorial and low-key where LePage is loud and pugnacious, said, "It's easy to underestimate me." And he also argued that outsiders underestimate the district's independent streak, particularly due to Trump's historic unpopularity.

LePage may remain the favorite — Trump carried the district by 9 points in 2024 — but winning may require him to do some uncharacteristic things: tone himself and his support for the president down.

Coming out of retirement in Flor-

LEPAGE, Page A10



PHOTOS BY DANIELLE PARHIZKARAN/GLOBE STAFF

Jennie MacPherson jumped at the chance for her own space, and was undeterred by the LoConte arena site.

A WARM SPOT FOR THE RINK

Medford cafe's always making something special, and not just for hockey players

By Scott Kathan
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

The first thing you notice about Sidebar Cafe in Medford is the cute, hand-drawn bird logo adorning the signage, and the fresh flowers and decorative pumpkins that signal the season. A menu board calls out Tandem coffee and MEM tea, an array of hearty sandwiches and leafy salads, and housemade baked goods like banana bread and muffins. The smell of warm cookies hangs in the air. And then the horn sounds to call an end to practice, and dozens of dewy youth hockey players trudge up to the cafe window to place their orders. Because Sidebar Cafe is smack-dab inside an ice rink.

The lobby of the LoConte facility, a 1970s-era arena wedged among East Medford's swirl of highways and big box stores, is standard-issue old-school rink: padded rubber floor, long benches for tying skates, and smudged display cases crammed with old trophies, team photos, and award plaques (future NHL players Keith Tkachuk, Joe Sacco, and Shawn Bates once skated there). The cafe sits off to the side, and visible inside the tidy 300-square-foot kitch-

CAFE, Page A7



Kids can have their pizza and popcorn, but Greek salad with pickled red onions and crispy chickpeas is also available.

Poll: Voters have qualms but stick with Healey

Trump's unpopularity is a major obstacle for Minogue

By Anjali Huynh
GLOBE STAFF

Very few Massachusetts voters believe the state has become a better place to live over the last four years. In fact, most respondents in a new Suffolk University/Boston Globe poll said they believe it's actually gotten worse.

That bleak outlook, however, does not have many clamoring for fresh faces.

With two weeks until Election Day, Governor Maura Healey appears primed to roll to reelection against her Republican challenger, Michael Minogue, among a group of Democratic incumbent statewide officials enjoying commanding leads over their Republican and lesser-known challengers, the poll found.

About 59 percent of the 500 likely general election voters surveyed said they would back Healey for a second term, while 36 percent planned to vote for Minogue, the former Abiomed executive who has cast the state as too expensive and insufficiently governed. Less than 4 percent of voters remained undecided — including some who were surveyed after two debates between the candidates — suggesting Minogue has little opportunity to woo disaffected voters.

One might think, given voter unhappiness, that Minogue could have more potential converts. While more than half of respondents said they believed Massachusetts was headed in the right direction, only 15 percent said the state has

POLL, Page A10

Bucking trend, Liberty Mutual plans to expand headquarters

By Catherine Carlock
GLOBE STAFF

At a time when the urban office market remains in an extended slump and many professionals still work from home, Liberty Mutual is making a big, expensive bet on Boston's business district.

The insurance giant is proposing to build out its headquarters in Back Bay by razing three nearby brick buildings for a complex that it says will be a workplace "for the next 100 years."

"We now have an opportunity to reimagine our Boston campus," Liberty spokesperson Glenn Greenberg said in a statement. "We're thinking strategically about what we'll need in the future, and over the next few years we will consolidate all employees and facilities at our headquarters into this one block of property."

The company detailed its proposal in a letter to the Boston Planning Department last week. Under the plan, Liberty Mutual would build a "vertical addition" on a wing off its existing 22-story headquarters tower at 157 Berkeley St. and a new 10-story structure off the intersection of Stuart Street and Columbus Avenue. The proposal includes fully occupying a prominent triangular space across

LIBERTY, Page A6



On the dark cider

Wednesday: Breezy, cooler. High 52-57. Low 45-50.

Thursday: Sun is back. High 61-66. Low 40-45.

High tide: 8:06 a.m., 8:19 p.m.

Sunrise: 7:04 Sunset: 5:53

Weather and Comics, G6-7.

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House leaders rejected Governor Maura Healey's plan to temporarily suspend the state's 24-cent-per-gallon gas tax, dropping it from the spending bill that lawmakers plan to pass Wednesday. **B1.**

A historic boulder fell at Polar Caves Park, a popular tourist site in New Hampshire. **B1.**

Stop & Shop's website was back online, more than a week after a cyberattack knocked the grocery chain's digital services offline. **B5.**

Scientists said that for the first time, they have used viruses designed by AI to treat a human patient. **A2.**

Many readers took the Globe to task for its list of the best 12 pizzas in the area. Check out the ones they say we seem to have missed. **G1.**

Chinatown has hope after draining of notorious puddle

By Danny McDonald
GLOBE STAFF

It's a welcome sight for Chinatown residents: Now, after a heavy rain, Ping On Alley is walkable without galoshes.

Long home to what locals considered a forever nuisance, a hassle that was as much a part of the neighborhood backdrop as the Chinatown Gate, the huge puddle that attracted jungle-thick mosquito hordes and flooded basements abutting the neighborhood's most historic byway is gone.

Well, sort of.

After a Globe front-page story, crews cleared a storm drain in the alley of gravel, pumped water out, and then injected bacteria into the underground drainage pipe to eat away any restaurant grease build-up in the line, according to abutters. Now, the rain-fueled pool has shrunk exponentially.

It used to be 30 paces long, but after a recent

PUDDLE, Page A7

ROUGH START FOR CELTICS



PAUL SANCYA/ASSOCIATED PRESS

In the season opener Tuesday afternoon, Boston raced out to a 22-point lead in the third quarter but then fell 121-113 as Detroit went on a 23-0 run in the fourth. New Celtic Paul George (above) scored 38 points but Jayson Tatum struggled. **C1.**